



NESTLÉ

Déjà vu

How will the latest controversy on Cerelac affect Nestlé?

BY ARNAB DUTTA

► **FOR NESTLÉ**, the Swiss packaged foods giant, it feels like history repeating itself. Nearly nine years after facing scrutiny over the quality of one of its top-selling products in India, there's a feeling of déjà vu. If it was Maggi instant noodles last time, now it's Cerelac infant cereal, another prized product. Following a recent report by Public Eye, a Swiss investigative organisation, and the International Baby Food Action Network (IBFAN), concerns have surfaced about added sugar in the popular infant cereal. This controversy is one Nestlé India would rather have avoided. The report highlights Nestlé's practice of

INDIAN SPICE BRANDS, MDH AND EVEREST, ARE ALSO UNDER SCRUTINY

adding sugar to Cerelac in countries like India, Thailand, and Ethiopia, while selling the same product without added sugar in wealthier nations like the UK and Germany. In other words, accusations of racism immediately came to the foreground.

Dismissing the accusations, Suresh Narayanan, Chairman and Managing Director of Nestlé India,

swiftly addressed the company's stance. During a press briefing, Narayanan emphatically refuted any suggestion of discriminatory practices based on race regarding the quality of food products sold by the company in Indian and European markets.

"There is no distinction done between a child in Europe and a child in India or any other part of the world. 'Added sugar' and 'no added sugar' products are present in Europe as well as in Asia," he said.

Furthermore, he emphasised that the level of additional sugar in Cerelac sold in India falls well below the permissible limits established